

Case Background

Criminal case: The Golden State Killer

Defendant: Joseph James DeAngelo Jr.

Location: California, United States

Crime Period: 1976-1986

Case status: Solve; DeAngelo pleaded guilty and received multiple life sentences without parole. Joseph DeAngelo was identified as the offender known by several names, including the East Area Rapist, the Original Night Stalker, and the Golden State Killer. Investigators linked him to a series of sexual assaults, burglaries, and murders across several California communities. The FBI reported that the crimes included 12 homicides, 45 rapes, and more than 120 burglaries.

How was it solved?

At first the case had remained unsolved for decades because investigators had crime-scene DNA but no identified suspect. In 2018, the Golden State Killer was apprehended using investigative genetic genealogy, which they used to compare with the crime-scene DNA, with the information gathered from the genealogy databases helped them build a family tree and narrow the search to DeAngelo. Investigators then collected DNA from an item he discarded, which matched DNA from the crime scenes. He was arrested in April 2018.

Court Outcome

In 2020, DeAngelo pleaded guilty to 13 counts of first-degree murder and admitted responsibility for additional violent crimes. He was sentenced on August 21, 2020, to life in prison without the possibility of parole.

Victim Typology

The GSK's victims were generally not responsible for causing or encouraging the crimes. They were targeted because of circumstances the offender could exploit such as living in locations he could access, being home at night, or being alone or with a partner.

- Completely innocent
- Suggest that the victims were more situational or accessible
- No evidence that the victims provoked or contributed to the attacks
- Mostly strangers; creating a risk of stalking, surveillance, and forced entry

Applying Criminological Theory

Chapter 4 Choice Theory argues that offenders make decisions based on perceived benefits and costs of crime. The offender may consider factors such as opportunity, risk of being caught, potential reward, and the effort required to commit the offense.

- This can be applied to Joseph DeAngelo because his crimes appeared planned rather than random.

- Surveilled neighborhoods
- selected residences
- entered homes of the victims when they were vulnerable
- Disguised himself and took steps to avoid identification

His repeated offending also indicates that he believed the perceived benefits, such as sexual gratification, power, and control, which outweighed the risks.

Chapter 5 Trait Theory argues that criminal behavior can result from biological, psychological, or personality traits, often combined with environmental influences.

- DeAngelo's conduct may be explained through traits associated with persistent antisocial behavior, including apparent lack of empathy, manipulation, aggression, deception, and disregard for the victims' rights.
- Over the years, his repeated offending suggests a subtle pattern of behavior rather than one isolated incident
- He could control his behavior when it serves his interests; serious planning and ability to maintain an ordinary public identity

Chapter 6 Social Structure Theory explains crime by examining the influence of social and economic conditions, including poverty, inequality, blocked opportunities, and neighborhood conditions. It is often used to explain why crime rates may be higher in disadvantaged communities.

- This theory is somewhat limited to be applied to the GSK case because DeAngelo was not typically described as an offender whose crimes resulted from poverty, unemployment, or a disadvantaged class position.
- So this theory is very weak to be applied since it does not explain his motivation or the beginning of his criminal career.

Best Theory

I believe the best theory that fits with this case is the Choice Theory. This theory has a better explanation for DeAngelo's crime pattern because it accounts for his planning, victim selection, and efforts to avoid detection.

- He planned and prepared; he didn't attack randomly:
 - stalked neighborhoods
 - watched potential victims
 - used threats and restraints

These actions suggested that he took his time and selected situations that offered access to victims while limiting the chance of interference. There is also risk assessment and adaptation, DeAngelo changed aspects of his offending over time. This suggests that he learned from previous offenses and adjusted his behavior when he believed that police or the public were becoming familiar with his pattern. Choice theory also explains why residential settings were attractive to him. Home provided privacy, familiar surroundings, and opportunities to surprise victims while they were sleeping. Nighttime attacks, disguises, stalking, and escape planning further reduced risks he perceived.